

Fifteen years ago, when I got my first job with benefits, I didn't even understand what a 401(k) was. I asked my husband, "What is a four-zero-one-k?" and he looked at me, confused. After explaining that my new employer was asking me to fill out a 401(k) form and that they offered an 8% match, he knew exactly what I was talking about. "Oh, the 401(k), that's a really good thing; you should max it out to get the match," he told me. That was the first time I ever heard about investing for retirement. It sounded like a good thing to do, to put money away every month before I could even spend it. So, I decided to contribute fifteen percent of my income. Out of sight, out of mind! After enrolling, I forgot about it. It never occurred to me to stop my contributions, not even during the 2008 financial collapse when my husband lost his job and our income went down sixty-five percent. I never want to become a financial burden on anybody. I also love the work that I do, so retirement is the last thing on my mind. However, investing in my 401(k) is an essential part of my financial plan, because it gives me peace of mind and affords me the luxury to anticipate retirement with excitement. I am confident that the day I decide to retire, it will be on my terms. I am looking forward to spending my mornings enjoying the sounds of nature, drinking coffee on the porch of my farmhouse, reading lifestyle magazines, and admiring the beauty of my horses roaming free through my twenty-acre property in the middle of nowhere. I am going to create this future myself and not rely on the government, the lottery, and most certainly not my kids to support my dreams. By the time I get to retirement age, I would have been investing diligently for forty years to make this future happen. Having that certainty gives you a different perspective on why it's essential to make the sacrifices to invest today in your tomorrow.

Kalyn's and Yezmin's stories are inspiring and quite the opposite from Anne's. However, there are lessons we can learn from all three stories as we plan out our futures. What choice would you rather make starting right now? You might not be in the same position as Kalyn and Yezmin where you started investing early, but the unique opportunity you have by gaining knowledge from reading this book is that you can start today.